

QA LEADERSHIP ACADEMY

Module 6 Assignment — Risk-Based Quality Leadership

Assignment brief: scenario, deliverables, steps and how your work is assessed.

About this assignment

A major Northstar release is scheduled for tomorrow. Two critical test areas are untested, fourteen medium-severity issues are open, there is an intermittent payment failure nobody can reliably reproduce, and 90% of the regression pass has completed and passed. Tom, the Head of Product, is pushing on the date; Marcus on the Payments squad is unconvinced QA should hold anything up. QA informs the decision — the business owns the go/no-go.

What you'll demonstrate

- Assess and communicate release risk under time pressure
- Separate QA's advisory role from the business's ownership of the decision
- Reason clearly about an intermittent, high-stakes payment issue
- Offer options and conditions, not just a blunt yes or no

What to submit

- A Release Risk Recommendation for tomorrow's release
- A completed Product Risk Matrix and Release Risk Assessment for the outstanding items
- A filled-in Go / No-Go Decision Template presenting the recommendation and residual risk

Step-by-step

1. Assess each outstanding item — the two untested criticals, the fourteen mediums and the intermittent payment fault — on the Product Risk Matrix
2. Complete the Release Risk Assessment, being explicit about what the 90% regression pass does and does not tell you
3. Reason about the intermittent payment issue specifically, given Northstar takes real customer money through a third-party provider and a legacy billing service
4. Frame two or three options for the business (ship, ship with conditions, or hold) with the residual risk of each

5. Write the recommendation using the Go / No-Go template, making clear QA informs and the business decides

Submission format

Submit as a PDF or DOCX — a recommendation a Head of Product could act on in minutes.

How your work is assessed

If a QA lead reviewed this, they would look for:

- Risk assessed by impact and likelihood, not by issue count alone
- The intermittent payment issue treated with the seriousness money-handling demands
- A clear line between QA's advice and the business's decision
- Options and conditions offered, not a single take-it-or-leave-it verdict
- Residual risk stated honestly so the decision-maker owns it with eyes open

Templates & resources to use

- Product Risk Matrix — find it in the Resource Vault.
- Release Risk Assessment — find it in the Resource Vault.
- Go / No-Go Decision Template — find it in the Resource Vault.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

Your job is not to say "no" — it is to make the residual risk so clear that whoever owns the decision owns it knowingly. An intermittent payment fault you cannot reproduce is exactly the kind of risk that must be named out loud, not buried in a count of fourteen mediums.